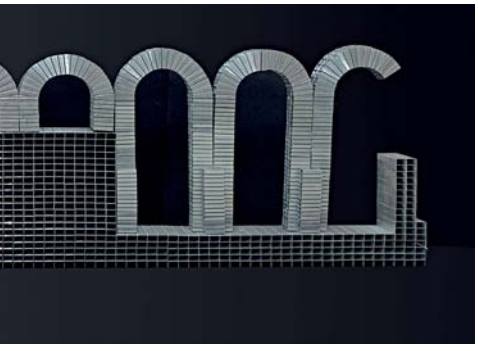
looking for art for their homes." Other potential young collectors were wooed through events as varied as a musical night at a Chhattarpur farmhouse, a tour of a private collection, and a Museum of Confiscated Antiquities walk about the ethico-legal dangers of acquiring traditional Indian art.

Still, a trusted gallerist remains the most reliable route for younger buyers. I met Ekta K., 45, as she supplemented her largely contemporary collection with Bastar figures and Bhuta masks from the Inherited Arts Forum, a platform tied to a gallery she has come to trust, Blueprint12. A Paris-based visitor to IAF for five years, she had also bought a work by the recently rediscovered landscape painter Rustom Siodia, who died in 1946. "Mort Chatterjee, of Chatterjee and Lal, told me about him: an artist who didn't get his due. And it brings me joy," she said.



Most buyers at **THE IAF** were not young, but many young curators were seen explaining a work to young visitors or introducing a young artist to do so

Most buyers at IAF weren't young, of course, and not all the young were buying, but the demographic was visibly more youthful than at the average gallery opening. Fashionably-dressed young women took selfies with sculptures, dating couples compared whispered notes over paintings, and almost everyone captured their favourites for Instagram. Many galleries had young curators in attendance, jumping in to explain a work or introducing an equally young artist to do so. I heard many 30-somethings ask the price of brighter, eye-catching works, only to hear it had been sold.

"Almost all galleries were sold out on Day One," agrees Reddy. "Many did a rehang. And we'd made sure to have two Preview Days instead of one—because after two Covid years, galleries were here to sell!" Higher sales may have something to do with more younger artists on show, especially from younger galleries. Nine new galleries showed at the fair this year, including Terrain.art, Art Incept and Modern Art Gallery from Delhi, Art Exposure from Kolkata and Vidya Heydari from Pune. "But a DAG, whose prices start from Rs 50 lakh and go up to Rs 5 crore, has done as well as a Jhaveri Contemporary, whose range is Rs 5 to 30 lakh," Reddy points out.

Another of Vazirani's rapid-fire questions was a fill-in-the-blank: "To you, culture is _____?" "A necessity," Kiran Nadar said immediately. Ironies aside, so it is. Whether you recognise it or not, no one can live without culture in some form. If you don't read fiction, you watch stories on TV or film or the web; if you don't 'get' poetry, you likely still have lyrics you live by. *Owning* a piece of contemporary visual art will remain a luxury. Still, making a huge variety of it more accessible to view, closely and freely—even at Rs 800 for the weekend (600 for students)—feels like a good thing. ■

–Trisha Gupta

IN GLOWING COLOURS

Young artists who made a mark at the IAF



VARUNIKA SARAF

Hyderabad-based Varunika Saraf, 39, has a PhD from JNU, and it shows. A manuscript interpreting apocalyptic events in 16th century Germany is adapted to depict dire omens in 21st century India. Caput Mortuum, a rust-red pigment associated with mummies and alchemy becomes the base for a deceptively tranquil series about state violence. Her work makes subtle, captivating use of the art historical archive while being political.



TSERING NEGI

Printmaker Tsering [also spelt Chhering] Negi, 34, grew up in Kinnaur, Himachal Pradesh and studied art at Chandigarh and Santiniketan. His woodcuts and lithographs craft recurring everyday motifs–windows, clouds, women's faces, cacti and roses–into something iconic.



MAHESH BALIGA

Trained in Mysore and Baroda, 40-year-old Mahesh Baliga uses painstakingly ground casein pigments to make his luminous miniature-inspired paintings. Reading the Ramayana, afloat in a boat or cutting their nails–his often solitary figures are somehow both absurd and melancholic. Baliga's first international solo show is on at David Zwirner, London, till May 28.